What's New on the AP U.S. History Exam

Two format changes for the 2026–27 course — and what stays exactly the same

College Board released an updated Course and Exam Description effective Fall 2026. The **content you study does not change** — same periods, same themes, same key concepts. But **two things about the exam format are new**. Here's what they mean for how you prepare.

THE TWO CHANGES

1 One Long Essay — no more choosing your prompt

The Long Essay Question (LEQ) used to give you **three prompts to pick from**, each on a different era. Now there is a **single, required** LEQ. The requirements themselves are unchanged (thesis, context, evidence, complexity), and the CED gives **no required time range** — it only says the prompt covers "approximately half of the chronological scope of the course." You still don't have to cover that entire span, but you no longer get to skip an era by picking a different question.

BEFORE (2023)
Choose 1 of 3 LEQ prompts, each on a set time band.

NOW (2026)
One required LEQ. No set year range — it covers about half the course's chronological scope.

> **What to do:** Prepare broadly across the whole course. You can't count on dodging a weak era — any large chronological span could be the prompt.

2 Short-Answer #3 is now a visual source

You used to **choose between two "no-stimulus"** short-answer questions (the ones with no source to read). That choice is gone. Now **all three SAQs are required**, and Question 3 always gives you a **non-text source** — a map, political cartoon, chart, graph, photograph, or other image — that you must analyze.

BEFORE (2023)
Pick Q3 or Q4; both had no source (text or otherwise).

NOW (2026)
Q3 required, always built on a non-text (visual) source.

> **What to do:** Practice reading images, maps, cartoons, and charts — what they show, who made them, and why. This is now a guaranteed skill on exam day.

WHAT HASN'T CHANGED

- ✓ The 9 time periods & their dates (1491–present)
- ✓ All 8 themes and the key concepts you study
- ✓ The 6 historical thinking skills
- ✓ DBQ: still 7 documents, use at least 4
- ✓ Same section weights & timing (below)
- ✓ Total exam length: 3 hours 15 minutes

EXAM AT A GLANCE

SECTION	%	TIME
Multiple-Choice (55 Qs)	40%	55 min
Short-Answer (3 Qs)	20%	40 min
Document-Based (DBQ)	25%	60 min
Long Essay (LEQ)	15%	40 min

Based on the College Board AP U.S. History Course and Exam Description, Effective Fall 2026. For study use in APUSH.